Spotlight Transcript: Asian Games

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Chapter 1: Introduction

[0:03] Anchor (Sarabjit Kore): [music] Spotlight. This is Akashwani. In the program spotlight, now we bring a discussion on Asian Games 2026. India's rise on the continental stage. The participants are G. Rajaraman, senior sports journalist and Sarabjit Kore, anchor.

Good evening listeners. Welcome to Spotlight. With the curtains coming down on the 20th Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, over the past two weeks, we have witnessed competition, **triumphs**, disappointments, and some truly memorable performances. For India, the games bring a bag of 85 medals, 21 gold, 27 silver, and 37 bronze, placing the country fourth in the overall standings.

But behind these numbers are stories of individual courage, team effort and a changing sporting landscape. So today as we look back at Aichi-Nagoya 2026, we ask what does this Asian games tell us about the present and future of Indian sport.

Chapter 2: Assessing the Performance

[1:09] Anchor: To discuss this and more, we are fortunate to have in our studios today, Mr. G. Rajaraman, senior sports journalist. Mr. Rajaraman, welcome to the discussion.

[1:19] G. Rajaraman: Thank you so much, Sarabjit.

[1:20] Anchor: Mr. Rajaraman we'll begin this discussion and we'll invite your thought process, we'll invite insights from you on the larger canvas of things. Looking at the larger picture what makes the Asian games such an important sporting event not just for the athletes but for the sporting **ambitions** of countries across Asia?

[1:37] G. Rajaraman: I think it's one event where India and other countries in Asia can expect to show that they are progressing as sporting nations so this is a good **barometer** for us to test where we are. And when we look at the larger picture, especially against the backdrop of Los Angeles 2028 Olympic Games, 85 is an okay performance.

It's not a great performance. It's something that does not make us very sad, nor should it make us very happy. It's a **lukewarm** performance for me overall, but there are some positives to take from here. There's some great lessons that if we heed, we will perform really well in Los Angeles as well.

Chapter 3: Benchmarks and Progression

[2:16] **Anchor:** So taking cue from what you just said, you described this performance as a lukewarm performance coupled with some lessons to learn. So I'd like to go back to the historic 107 medal haul at the Hangzhou. Now how would you assess India's journey in the Asian games over the years?

[2:31] **G. Rajaraman:** To be very honest, Hangzhou was a brilliant performance. We were not expecting a 100 medals. There was a marketing campaign which said "Is baar 100 paar" and when we crossed that, we were all very happy with that kind of a performance. Now that set up a new benchmark for us. It is the best performance ever by an Indian **contingent** in an Asian game. Now the expectation is you will get better than that, or at least match it. That did not happen and that is why a sense of disappointment was **pervading** across the sporting community.

But the last few days infused a lot of positivity and enthusiasm back in the sporting ecosystem thanks to the boxers and the wrestlers and the archers picking up so many medals in the last few days. It truly revived the positivity that was missing for some days.

Chapter 4: Resurgence of Hockey

[3:16] **Anchor:** So continuing you said that bringing some positivity in the environment and medals coming up in the last few days. The biggest story for India has been hockey and both the men's and women's teams won gold and the men's victory also brought Olympic qualification. You just mentioned about the Los Angeles 2028 Olympics. So I'd like to have your comment on this. What does this tell us about the **resurgence** and **consistency** of Indian hockey in particular?

[3:42] **G. Rajaraman:** I think the women's team deserves a lot more praise because they have staged a comeback.

They did not make it to the Olympic Games in Paris in 2024. From there to ensure that they will play the Los Angeles Olympic Games a full 2 years before the games are due to begin is fantastic effort. And the way they defended against China after scoring that one goal was fabulous to watch.

I think the men you would expect them to dominate Asia. So therefore they have matched the expectations. As hockey fans, as critics, we expect the men's hockey team especially to go out there and dominate the rest of the world. Beat the Germans, the Spain, the Belgiums and the Australias of the world. So that we come on to the top bracket again. We were bronze medalists both in Tokyo and in Paris. But India needs to do a little better than that and revive that magical experience that we've got for hockey with eight gold medals behind us. We need to find that gold again.

Chapter 5: Women in Indian Sport

[4:37] **Anchor:** Raj, you very rightly said that women have made an **emphatic** comeback. Now, how significant is the growing participation and success of women at the Asian Games for the future of Indian sports?

[4:46] **G. Rajaraman:** Oh, we've come a long way from the time Kamaljit Sandhu became the first woman to win an Asian games gold medal back in 1970 to now where the women are leading the fight for gold medals. We saw Niru Dhanda in trap shooting. We have seen Kumut Mo in archery and there have been several others who have done really well. The women's hockey team of course, the squash team has done really well. There is Anahat Singh who's just 18 years old and gives us hope. So a lot of women have done well and it is actually a result of all the good work of the last 10 or 15 years where we have encouraged a lot more women to go out and play sport.

Chapter 6: Building an Ecosystem

[5:44] **Anchor:** So somewhere you're also hinting at a complete sports **ecosystem** supporting the budding sportsmen and sports women of the country.

So as viewers we see an athlete standing on the podium but behind that moment there is coaching, there is sports science, nutrition, mental conditioning, international exposure, years of preparation. Now how important has this support ecosystem become in the country and what is the country's growth journey towards this?

[6:07] **G. Rajaraman:** I think when Leander won the 1996 bronze medal in Atlanta Olympic Games, we did not have this kind of support. Even when Abhinav Bindra became the first Indian individual to win a gold medal in the Olympic Games back in 2008, the support system was not so strong. But over the last 10-12 years, we have seen TOPS being brought in which is the Target Olympic Podium Scheme. There's Khelo India as well. But we need a good assembly line and I think the states have a responsibility and if we can somehow get the states all to understand that and deliver their goods, we will become a better sporting nation.

Chapter 7: Diversifying Sporting Culture

[7:08] **Anchor:** While an ecosystem is very important and support at the state level and contribution from the central government towards the sporting culture in the country, are we also talking about a broader sporting culture especially in the context of the Asian games? Is there a shift in focus from the traditional games?

[7:24] **G. Rajaraman:** I truly hope that our cyclists, our swimmers, there's lots of other sport. There are many sports where we haven't picked up medals where there are multiple medals available and if we can ensure that more children play these sports and maybe in the next 8-10 years we start winning medals in the Asian games in this sport.

[8:12] **Anchor:** So the potential indeed needs to be **harnessed** also from the grassroot level.

Chapter 8: Mindset of Young Athletes

[8:16] **Anchor:** And taking the discussion further from here, one striking feature of Indian sport today is the **emergence** of young athletes. What is changing the way young Indians are preparing themselves to compete at the international level?

[8:27] **G. Rajaraman:** I think one of the most striking aspects for me in the last few years has been the fearlessness which our athletes go out. There was a time when our athletes would go to bring up the numbers.

But I think our athletes are now hungry. There's a lot of awards and reward that come their way when they do well and I think it's a way of life for many of them now. People have realized that sport can be a career option.

[9:26] Anchor: Raj, in spite of all the fearlessness, we cannot deny that there is **tremendous** expectation attached to wearing the Indian jersey. So, how does an athlete manage the pressure of representing an entire country at a competition of this scale?

[9:37] G. Rajaraman: I think they focus on the moment. They don't think about the 1.5 billion Indians and the pressure of that expectation. I think the beautiful lesson that sport offers all of us is to be mindful is to live in the present moment.

Chapter 9: Lessons for the Future

[10:06] Anchor: And of course we as any other country we are not competing in **isolation**. What can we as an emerging nation as far as sports is concerned learn from the sporting systems of other Asian countries?

[11:30] G. Rajaraman: We need to give them the responsibility, show them the love and affection and then we can start demanding **accountability** from them.

Chapter 10: Role of Education and Youth

[11:51] G. Rajaraman: I think this was a wakeup call for us before the Los Angeles Olympic Games and the 2030 Asian Games. Had we crossed 100, we would have been a little bit more **complacent**. I think it is just as well that we picked up only 85 medals and we can go back to the drawing board.

Chapter 11: Conclusion

[13:50] Anchor: The Asian Games may end with the closing ceremony, but for every athlete, the journey continues. Behind every medal is a story of discipline, **resilience**, and the courage to dream. And perhaps that is the greatest lesson the games leave with us. Mr. Rajaraman, thank you very much for sparing your valuable time.

[14:11] Outro: Thank you very much. You were listening to a discussion on Asian Games 2026 India's rise on the continental stage. This program is produced and presented by the news services division of Akashwani. You can listen to it on a mobile app news on air.